

metroPLUS

THE HINDU

Tamil indie musician Kaber Vasuki
on what is playing on his mind and playlist **P2**

ARJUN, ADITI GET READY
FOR ONCE MORE **P4**



Perfect snap From the early days of the Madras Crocodile Bank Trust on the ECR. They began their 50th year, hosting over 400 crocodiles on their premises besides other species. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Fifty years after Rom and Zai Whitaker founded the Madras Crocodiles Bank Trust, with wedding gifts and a dream, the zoo shelters reptiles and a community committed to conservation

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Zai Whitaker distinctly remembers Madras Crocodile Bank Trust's (MCBT) first-ever gharial. As incredulous as it sounds, it arrived in a box.

The small zoo dedicated to reptiles on what was once a desolate East Coast Road in Tamil Nadu had been up and running since 1976 when among the rarest crocodilians on Earth, made its way to Chennai from somewhere in Central/ North India. A pen was dug up in the 1980s with some water to accommodate this river guardian that was most critically endangered because human activities had destroyed its freshwater river habitat. Down South was certainly one way to go. "The gharial came in a box... I think the carrier was from Kukrail, Uttar Pradesh. We [co-founder Rom and a few animal handlers] were standing around it. When the animal is released from the box, you don't know what it's going to do, where it's going to go. We were waiting and watching. Fortunately, it was very well behaved. It ran straight into the water, and since then there has been no looking back," she says.

Fifty years since it first began, over 47 gharials (out of 395 crocs) have made the MCBT their home. This is besides the 32 other reptile species including the three Indian crocodilians, turtles, snakes, and lizards, across the eight and a half acre campus. Hundreds of animal handlers, educators,

volunteers, staff members, and researchers make Croc Bank the institution it is. Rom and Zai, who made this small piece of land in Vadanamelli village their home, have gone on to pioneer a number of marquee programmes including the Snake Bite Mitigation Project, benefitting and making reptilian research essential reading in India.

At the Croc Bank today, where Zai sits near a hatchery to write and oversee operations, a quiet enthusiasm takes over the space. As



we walk through the quieter parts of the campus, amidst trees that the duo planted, half a century ago, Zai says that the years both seem to shrink and expand. Time is, after all, relative.

Pothole portal

The story began during a point of affliction: a crisis. By the 1960s, hunting crocodiles for their skin had pushed their population into decline. Indian crocs like the mugger crocodile, saltwater crocodile, and gharials, faced massive existential threats. The Indian Government decided it was time to protect the three species under the Wildlife Protection Act of 1972. Zai says that by then, herpetologist Romulus 'Rom' Whitaker was already a well-known conservationist in India. He had been conducting several crocodile

surveys besides setting up and running the Snake Park at Guindy. The idea for the croc bank came to him while he was sitting atop a truck, hitching a ride home from a crocodile survey in 1972 all the way from Odisha.

"I think he was coming back because he'd run out of money. This wonderful truck driver gave him a free ride all the way from Orissa to the gate of the Snake Park in Chennai. So he wrote me this letter, which I should still have somewhere, saying why don't we start a croc-breeding facility, and then reward them with the help of the Forest Department. 'People could come to visit and look at the animals, so maybe we could charge a ticket, and the future Mrs Whitaker' – because by then we were talking about getting married – would have some daily income for food and other necessities. That was actually how it started," Zai says.

The Madras Crocodile Bank was formally established on August 26,



extracting snake venom for anti-venom production.

Zai says that they have been intent on building a passionate team. She particularly remembers researchers who recently passed, including Jagannathan Vijaya, Satish Bhaskar, and D Basu. "We would tell them 'There are dacoits there, and you'll spend the night sleeping on the sand banks with pythons'. The response of these three people was, 'oh yeah, that's great, I would love to do that'. We thought that we were doing them a favour. But these were people who created the space in India to conserve sea turtles, freshwater turtles, and the gharial. Their initial studies were what took that conservation movement forward. I hope that continues," she says.

What it takes

When we meet 38-year-old second generation animal handler G Gowrishankar, we realise what Zai means. The crocs recognise his voice and amble towards him. Someone in the crowd who watches him call to the muggers in the pit next to us, remarks, "Who is this guy? He's herding them like they are goats".

Gowrishankar says that some of these beasts have become his favourites. Over time, he has learnt to enter the pits, feed specific crocs, assess their health, and even catch and quarantine them in case of ailments. This is strenuous work that requires brute strength, tactic, and an understanding of the animal.

Vaibhavi Bhardwaj, who grew up loving animals and wanting snakes for pets, is now a zoo educator at MCBT. She is a big proponent of the volunteer programme and says that it is a great jump-off point for those who wish to seriously enter the conservation space. She says that besides the public interactions she does during feed timings, where she tells people about the reptiles, and debunks myths about specific species, she conducts reptile awareness programmes for schools, and snake bite mitigation campaigns. She also educates volunteers and tells them how a zoo runs.

"One of the things volunteers participate in is husbandry activities: maintenance and constant checking on the reptiles. Reptiles are really hard to catch illness in, because they're very good at masking anything that's wrong – it's a survival instinct for them. Our keepers are trained to observe small abnormalities in behaviour, which they do every morning," she says, speaking about how a zoo runs.

Today, as part of entering their 50th year celebrations, Ganesh Muthiah, trustee, MCBT, says that he will embark on a 15,000 kilometre journey across 20 Indian states over 120 days. The idea is to educate people about a Save the Reptiles Campaign that they are launching. This is besides a number of activities including photography and film contests. "We are excited," says this volunteer-turned-trustee, who is ever enthusiastic to speak about the days of yore. "Rom is like our Indiana Jones," he adds.

STEPOUT



Echoes of Madras

Anaivaram 2: Echoes of Existence is a celebration of inclusivity, heritage, photography and the many ways of experiencing Chennai. Bringing together hearing impaired artists, performers, and storytellers, the event explores the city through visual art, Indian Sign Language, poetry, photography, and heritage narratives. The event features an art exhibition by 12 artists, visual vernacular performances, an ISL song, heritage, and stories of Chennai from hearing impaired perspectives. @Goethe Institute, Nungambakkam. August 29, 10am to 12pm. Entry is free.



A toast to the city

Madrasapattinam celebrates the spirit of Madras through a contemporary food and cocktail experience inspired by the city's flavours. Local ingredients are reimaged in dishes, while signature cocktails pay tribute to the people, places and stories that have shaped the city. Highlights include Marina crispy corn, podi thooval loaded fries, and parotta smash burger sliders, alongside cocktails such as Maami's Martini, Miss Malli and Marina Goyya. @The Park, Six 'O' One, Pasha and The Leather Bar. The a la carte menu is on till August 31. For reservations, call 28246000.



Chennai: A living legacy

LEGACIES: Memories, Culture, Traditions – Madras to Chennai brings together eight Chennai-based artists who explore the city's layered identity and its journey from Madras to Chennai. Curated by Ashrifi S Bhagat, the exhibition features paintings, printmaking, and sculptures inspired by the city's architecture, communities, textiles, traditions, and everyday life. From coastal communities and historic neighbourhoods to Madras checks and urban landscapes, the works offer diverse ways of experiencing Chennai. @nKo Centre, RA Puram. On till September 22 from 10.30am to 5pm.



Going back in time

Explore Chennai through its food and history with two engaging events. The Mylapore Food Walk takes participants through some of the neighbourhood's most popular food joints, offering a chance to discover local flavours at one of Chennai's oldest neighbourhoods. The walk is open to all. Starts at Indian Bank gate, North Mado Street, Mylapore. On Aug 29 from 5pm to 7pm. There is a talk by Sudha Umashanker on Chandragiri Fort and its connection to the founding of Madras. @Hotel Palmgrove, Nungambakkam. August 30, 9.30am. To register, call 9840247624.

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You could feel the energy shift at a packed Music Academy in Chennai on Saturday when indie music sensation Kaber Vasuki made a rousing entrance. He made no effort to hide his wish to set hearts on fire – the evening began with the fiery rap track ‘Thirikilli.’ The show, part of his Frangipani tour, featured several hits stitched together with a story the composer narrated. A day after the show, as he joins us for a free-flowing conversation, Kaber is at his reflective best. In the story he narrates on his tour, Kaber says that he came to Chennai to become a ‘rockstar.’ And he is indeed one now. Kaber looks so comfortable being a showman on stage, wielding a mesmerising grip on the show. “I get into my flow state on stage. I feel most alive when I am performing. Here (regular life) is where I feel most uncomfortable,” he says, adding that sometimes it can be challenging to defeat his inner self-critical voice and to lock into this ‘flow state.’ “But what surprises me is how even the audience seems to be aware of when I need a push.” The highlight of the show is the hit track ‘Frangipani’, which has become an anthem of grief for many. Even if you have listened to ‘Frangipani’ in the comfort of your home, watching what it does to a hall of people is an experience unlike any other. It pushes audiences to a deeply personal space. The experience is so overwhelming that you don’t wish to touch the person sitting next to you, fearing they would break apart like glass, or you would. Kaber says he is still surprised that the track takes audiences into such fragile spaces.

Indie musician Kaber Vasuki opens up on his Frangipani tour, the ‘flow state’ he gets into on stage, and why he might stop performing a song by the end of this tour

“I am aware I am entering such a space when I am performing the song. And, like every song I perform, I try to be honest and go back to the emotional state I was in when I wrote that song. What the audience feels is something I wouldn’t know, at least before the song ends and they start reacting to it. When I started ‘Frangipani’, I didn’t intend to take people to such fragile spaces. I was just expressing

myself.” Performing ‘Frangipani’ takes a toll on Kaber. “Much of the song is about me remembering Nila, and so I invariably end up recollecting something about her. Sometimes it would trigger a new memory of Nila. Even now, people who knew Nila come up to me and share their experiences.” Which is why Kaber might retire ‘Frangipani’ by the end of this tour. “I don’t know how long I can sing

this song for. After a point, it will become performative. That might feel very weird. I don’t know; these are very confusing thoughts.” During the show, the organisers also screened ‘Oozhi,’ a music video featuring Kaber and actor Aditi Balan. Being anxious about appearing in front of the camera, Kaber needed some assistance with acting. “I surrendered to Lingesh, Aditi

and our acting coach, Jenny Bharathi. But after a point, I felt quite comfortable; I understood what would reflect well on camera. I can now say that I feel quite interested in acting as a craft.” Kaber wishes to stay away from the rat race the record label ecosystem pushes artistes into. If so, how does Kaber define success? “My issue is not that metrics are treated as success. That is also a kind of

success, but we cannot objectively compare the numbers of two artists. For me, success is helping my family lead a comfortable life while still doing the things I want to do. Secondly, I see how happy the people around me are, how excited they are to work with me, and whether they are seeing growth in their lives. Moreover, I feel successful if my work touches people’s hearts.”

Patterns of a lost tradition

Vintage Chettinad saris blend bold patterns, clever design and functionality

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Not every sari in a Chettinad household was meant for the women of the family. Coarsely woven cotton saris were kept aside for women from neighbouring villages who came to help during family functions. Recalling these saris from her childhood, Visalakshi Ramaswamy says the women in her household wore silk saris for festivals and at home, while the cotton saris, known as Kottiyur Kandangi, were reserved for those who came to assist during family functions. Named after Kottiyur, the village where they were woven, these saris offer a glimpse into a textile tradition that has largely disappeared from everyday use. Today, more than 20 such vintage saris are on display at DakshinaChitra Heritage Museum as part of Kodu, Kattam, Korvai: The Saris from the Houses of Chettinadu, an exhibition presented in collaboration with the Indian Institute of



Heritage in cotton Vintage Chettinad cotton saris from the collection on display at DakshinaChitra. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Crafts and Design (IICD), Jaipur. The collection comprises rare heritage cotton saris collected and preserved by French textile scholar and connoisseur Julie Wayne. The exhibition draws attention to the distinctive visual vocabulary of the Chettinad sari tradition. Kodu refers to a line, kattam to a check or grid, and korvai to the precise interlocking technique used to join the body and border of the sari on the loom. Together, these elements create a deceptively simple visual language: bold lines, checks, stripes and

carefully constructed borders. “The hallmark of this collection is its symmetry and mastery of construction,” says Visalakshi, founder of the M. Rm. Rm. Cultural Foundation, which works to preserve Chettinad culture and crafts. The fabric had to be strong enough to withstand bending, drawing water and fieldwork, while remaining porous enough to allow the body to breathe in Chettinad’s heat. Even the two decorated ends, or double pallu, served a practical purpose. When one end wore out,

the sari could be turned around and worn from the other, extending its life through its very construction. Dingdi Gangte, textile conservator at DakshinaChitra, points to another aspect of the collection: its individuality. “Each of these saris has to be appreciated like a work of art. These are handwoven masterpieces, and most of the saris in our collection bear the initials of the women who inherited them.” The saris in the collection vary in size and are characterised by a striking palette of crimson, yellow, orange, black, indigo and green. For Bessie Cecil, professor at the IICD and curator of the exhibition, kodu, kattam and korvai form the fundamental design structure of many Chettinad saris, creating an aesthetic that is at once simple, bold and deeply rooted in the region’s textile culture. *Kodu, Kattam, Korvai, is on till August 31. 10am to 5pm. @Kadambari Gallery, DakshinaChitra, Muttukadu. For details, call 9841020149.*

City takes stage

As Chennai turns 387, the Made of Chennai festivities draw to a close with an evening of music and food

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After a month of celebrating Chennai through its history, heritage and culture, the Made of Chennai festivities will end where the city arguably feels most at home: around food, music and a crowd. The Food and Music Festival, set to take place at YMCA grounds, Nandanam on August 29, will bring together live performances, food brands and entertainment. Music will take centrestage, with singer Chinmayi Sripada, Paal Dabba, Antony Dassan, Vihara and Makka bands bringing five distinct sounds to the festival. For singer Chinmayi, Chennai is the city where she grew up, learnt music and began her career, but also one that has seen the difficult parts of her life. “Chennai has seen every part of my very roller-coaster life. My upbringing, my music learning, my break, and my subsequent ban, all of this is Chennai. I think it has taught me a lot,”

she says. At the festival, Chinmayi will bring ‘Neelothi’, ‘Eppadi Vandhaayo’, and ‘Muththa Mazhai’ to the stage. Vihara’s sound moves between Carnatic, retro songs, rock, blues and funk. “People have always been very accepting of listening to something new. When we play a Carnatic song at high energy, even the traditional crowd is very enthusiastic,” says Abishek Varadarajan, guitarist for the band, adding that they plan to perform their versions of familiar Ilaiyaraaja hits and AR Rahman favourites. This ecosystem has also shaped musicians who were not born in Chennai, but raised by it. All three members of MAKKA Band are originally from Kerala, but grew up in the city. “Chennai truly feels like home because everything that we have today is what the city has given us. All the amazing songs, all the lovely hits, the love, the people, everything is what Chennai means to us,” says Ranjith Govind (vocals and ukulele). The festival’s food line-up brings together newer favourites and familiar



Chennai staples. There will also be a recreation of the Mannady Ramzan street food experience. Those attending the festival can enter the festival through YMCA Gate 1 or the SPIC Ground entrance on Chamiers Road. Limited parking will be available, so visitors are encouraged to use the Metro.

To register for the Food & Music Festival by Made of Chennai, log on to newsth.live/MOC2026ED.

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METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #68
(Set by Doppelganger)

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Across
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3 Excessively sentimental (8)
9 Wild duck (7)
10 Disagree (5)
11 Relating to birth (5)
12 Stumble (6)
14 Mobile device (6)
16 Mother's sister (6)
19 Former female student of college (6)
21 Glowing coal (5)
24 Small insect harmful to plants (5)
25 Passageway in body (7)
26 Provider (8)
27 Second hand (4)
Down
1 To cover card with plastic (8)
2 Cove (5)
4 Systemise (6)
5 Metal disc given as reward (6)
6 Flickering lightly (7)
7 Cipher (4)

Solution No. 68

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Remains of the past

Behind Royapuram's historic facades are stories of people who once called it home

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In the early 20th Century, Chennai's Royapuram underwent a transformation that made it look distinct from the rest of Madras. With the sea on one side, music spilling from every corner, and a large Anglo-Indian population jamming to it, Royapuram felt almost foreign. Now, the echoes of that music have faded, and Royapuram, with its busy narrow streets and jade buildings, has blended into the rest of Chennai. These stories were revisited during a heritage walk led by architect Muhilann M and S Prasanna in collaboration with NinetyEight.Madras and *The Hindu's* Made of Chennai.

The story of the Anglo-Indians can be traced back to the construction of the Royapuram Railway station in 1856. This piece of history stands to this day as the oldest surviving railway station in India. "When the Madras Railway Company was formed, many of those working there, including railway engineers, were Anglo-Indians. Several of them began settling in Royapuram," says Muhilann. A short walk away leads to St Peter's Church in Royapuram. Painted blue and white, the building tells a story dating back to the 1790s, when the Nawab of Arcot sought to move closer to the British seat of power at Fort St George. His request was denied, and he was allotted land in Chepauk, where the Chepauk Palace now stands.

However, the construction of the palace required the fishing community to relocate to Royapuram. After their resettlement, the community, in search of a place of worship, came together and contributed to the construction of St Peter's Church. "The church is linked to

Forgotten footprints Parsi Anjuman Baug in Royapuram. B JOTHI RAMALINGAM

one of the many stories surrounding the origins of the name Royapuram. St Peter is known as Rayappan in Tamil, and according to one version, the neighbourhood derived its name from the saint," says Muhilann. A few steps away from St Peter's Church stands the Parsi Anjuman Baug, adorned with Indo-Saracenic architecture and constructed in 1900, quietly narrating the story of the Parsis who once lived in the neighbourhood. "This is a guest house where members of our community can stay," says Mahiar F Shroff, a senior member of Parsi Anjuman Baug. "There are around 75 Parsi families in Chennai. Royapuram was once the stronghold of Parsis, but now we are shrinking in numbers," he adds. Many of Royapuram's historic structures have faded, but its churches, railway station and community spaces still preserve fragments of a past shaped by generations that lived here.



LEGO builders, get ready! Brickathon, a LEGO speed building contest, by Cubotics in collaboration with Wisfield International School, invites children aged three to 14 to put their speed and problem-solving skills to the test. The event encourages hands-on learning through LEGO building while introducing children to STEM, engineering and creative thinking. @Wisfield International School, Chengalpattu. August 30. Fee is ₹200 per participant. To register, call 8754100726. Timing will be announced.

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Love takes centrestage

Why Arjun Das and Aditi Shankar call *Once More* a ‘clean, musical love story’

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Tamil cinema has been reminding its fans that August is Romance Awareness Month. Every Friday of the month has seen on-screen romance in a distinct shade. If it was the bloody, revenge-fuelled tryst in *DC*, the Independence Day week saw Suriya in an age-gap romance in *Vishwanath & Sons*. The third week saw many little rom-coms like *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam* and *Modha Rathiri*. And now, this coming week, two romance dramas are set to hit the screens: *Hi* and *Once More*.

Debutant director Vignesh Srikanth's *Once More* promises to celebrate love in its most tender, most lyrical form. The film starring Arjun Das, Aditi Shankar and Sona Olickal has generated a lot of buzz online over the last two years, especially thanks to composer Hesham Abdul Wahab's stirring songs. The musical romance drama has had a long journey since its inception, while its lead star Arjun has had a longer journey with director Srikanth; the latter worked as an assistant director in Bejoy Nambiar's *Por*, which starred Arjun. "When I heard this narration, it was a beautiful story with a lot of emotions

and drama, and it was a clean musical love story," Aditi, on the other hand, had a lot of faith in it, since Yuvaraj Ganesan of Million Dollar Studios was backing the project. What she didn't expect, however, was to see Srikanth use a playlist of popular songs as references during the narration. "Every scene will have a reference from the playlist, which consists of songs in Tamil, Hindi and Malayalam. Even when we are shooting those scenes, those songs would be playing in the background to bring us into that mood." The Internet community knows Srikanth as a Mani Ratnam fanatic, and given that his guru Bejoy also hails

Love and love only
Arjun Das and Aditi Shankar in *Once More*.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

from Mani Ratnam's school of cinema, one can expect some inadvertent influences in the film, says Arjun. "There will be glimpses of Mani Ratnam in *Once More*, because many of his references were from that school of cinema." What AR Rahman's soundtrack did to several Mani Ratnam films is what composer Hesham's songs attempt to do in *Once More*. "Hesham has elevated every scene with his scores." Post his scene-stealing turns in films such as *Kaithi* and *Master*, Arjun has solidified his position as a sought-after actor – one who could pull off a crazy dual role in a big-star film like *Good Bad Ugly*, while also losing himself in characters in mid-budget flicks. "It's not a conscious decision. There were times when I was waiting for a good script, and now that the scripts are coming, I want to pick the movies that I really have my heart in." Arjun Das' unmistakable bass continues to be a distinct feature but comes with its own challenges. "After *Master*, there was feedback that there was no clarity in certain words that I said. Since then, I made a conscious point to take some time in the dubbing studio," says Arjun, whose upcoming projects include a family entertainer with director Ranjit Jeyakodi, a psychological thriller directed by Madhumita Sundararaman, Balaji Mohan's Netflix Series *#Love* and Vignesh Venugopal's *Super Hero*.

Once More releases in theatres on August 28

Mist as a messenger

Ahead of its digitally restored 4K re-release, cinematographer PC Sreeram revisits Mani Ratnam's *Geethanjali*

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May 12, 1989. Mani Ratnam's Telugu film *Geethanjali* was released rather quietly. It took time for the love story starring Nagarjuna Akkineni and Girija, with haunting music by Ilayaraja, to become a rage across erstwhile Andhra Pradesh. It remains one of the most memorable love stories in Telugu cinema. Its Tamil dubbed version *Idhayathai Thirudathe* was equally phenomenal at the box office in Tamil Nadu. Thirty-seven years later, the digitally restored film will re-release in 4K format in Telugu and Tamil on August 28, 2026.

Geethanjali is titled after its female protagonist (played by Girija) whose zest for life belies the fact that her days are probably numbered. The story follows her journey and that of Prakash (Nagarjuna), diagnosed with chronic myeloid leukemia.

Geethanjali was PC Sreeram and Mani Ratnam's fourth collaboration following *Mouna Ragam*, *Nayakan* and *Agni*

Natchathiram. "When Mani Ratnam discussed this idea of a love story between two characters with a medical condition taking place in a new geography – in a hill station – I wanted to use mist as the third factor or rather a messenger that unites them," recalls cinematographer PC Sreeram.

In the Eighties, a character in a mainstream film grappling with a terminal medical condition was nearly becoming a cliché. However, *Geethanjali* presented two such characters but turned the narrative into a happy story, Sreeram says: "The idea was to show how the characters want to be happy, irrespective of the situation."

The hills of Ooty and its surroundings became another character of the film, and the visuals established the mood of the narrative. "When I look back, the predominant memory is that of mist, through which we see Nagarjuna and Girija."

Geethanjali was filmed in the winter months and diligent planning ensured that the shooting was completed within 60 days. "Ooty was not crowded back then and we were able to film in real locations with ease. We shot in mist conditions when possible and at other times, used

artificial mist. For some of the indoor portions that show the mist moving from the open doors or windows towards the characters, we used dry ice," says Sreeram.

When *Geethanjali* was digitally restored by Prasad Corp recently for its re-release, Sreeram checked the quality of the restoration, including the colour grading. "The restored version retains the original colours, textures and contrasts. Nothing has changed. The audience today has several means of entertainment, unlike the times of *Geethanjali* when cinema was the biggest draw. But it's good to see the anticipation for the re-release."



Looking back
Nagarjuna Akkineni and Girija in *Geethanjali*



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